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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

ILLINOIS LEGISLATURE

As session nears end, sights set on critical bills

Public transit funding, pension reform, budget and Bears stadium are big issues in final week

By **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Illinois lawmakers head into the final days of their spring session this week looking for ways to close a substantial gap in the budget while at the same time shoring up ailing public transit operations and

taking steps to fix inequities in the state's pension system.

The General Assembly also could move on Gov. JB Pritzker's legislative goals, such as further abortion protections and cryptocurrency regulation. Also still unresolved is whether the state will provide any help for the Chicago Bears' potential relocation to Arlington Heights.

As happens every spring, much of the most serious business in the four-month spring legislative session has been left to the final hours.

But legislative leaders have also warned there's also a chance that, to maintain a balanced budget, legislators will have to return to Springfield after their scheduled adjournment on Saturday, May 31, because of uncertainty over federal funding under President Donald Trump's administration.

Democratic Sen. Elgie Sims of Chicago, the lead budget negotiator for the Senate Democrats, likened the situation with federal funding to the factors that led to a two-year plus budget impasse under Republican Gov. Bruce Rauner, which decimated social services and hurt the state's economy.

"There was a great deal of uncertainty, so we couldn't predict what was going to happen from one moment to the next," Sims said.

"It has a feel like that coming out of Washington. But that's why you have to stay the course, make sure that we have a clear understanding of what the priorities are, of what the needs are."

While Democrats have solid control of the General Assembly, haggling about the \$55.2 billion budget Pritzker proposed in February could divide party progressives and moderates, especially over

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MEMORIAL DAY



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

‘FOR THE HEROES’

Joe Caruso, of Naperville, leaves roses at the crosses for his son Marine Sgt. David M. Caruso and other fallen veterans Sunday during a Memorial Day event at the DuPage County Veterans' Memorial in Wheaton. Sgt. Caruso was killed in battle in Fallujah, Iraq, in 2004. The memorial, established at the county government center campus in 1999, commemorates DuPage residents killed in military conflicts since the Black Hawk War of 1832. "Memorial Day is for the heroes that are on these plaques," said George Kouba, a member of the group that has organized ceremonies at the site for 23 years. The memorial includes a sundial to acknowledge sacrifice over time and a garden of crosses for those who died most recently.

The world's best-preserved fossils can be found right outside Chicago

But there are no giant dinosaur bones at Mazon Creek

By **Adriana Pérez**
Chicago Tribune

Sixty-five miles southwest of Chicago, a small hill that looks like a prop from an Indiana Jones movie breaks up the flat, monotone landscape. Consisting of shale, sandstone and rocks from an old coal mine, the waste pile — located on a massive river delta from another era — is an unremarkable remnant from the region's once-thriving coal industry.

Except it contains many of the world's best-preserved, most diverse fossils.

The defunct mine's location in Grundy County is one of several sites spanning six counties that belong to the Mazon Creek fossil beds, a time capsule dating back some 309 million years — way



Rich Holm, a member of the Earth Science Club of Northern Illinois, on May 8 shows a *Tullimonstrum*, or Tully monster, found at the Mazon Creek fossil beds in Braceville, Illinois. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

before the age of dinosaurs — to the Carboniferous period, when large coal deposits formed around the world and terrestrial ecosystems developed. At the time, this area was swampy and tropical, and home to various organisms

like the Illinois state fossil, the peculiar Tully monster, which has been found only here — a cigar-shaped vertebrate creature up to a foot long with eyes that protruded

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Soaring payouts for police lawsuits hit record amount

Settlements for cases of alleged misconduct strain city budget

By **Jake Sheridan**
and **Joe Mahr**
Chicago Tribune

Chicago's spending on police misconduct settlements and other police lawsuits is soaring this year, and the steep price for taxpayers could rise hundreds of millions more.

Through May alone, the City Council has already approved at least \$145.3 million in taxpayer payments to settle lawsuits involving the Chicago Police Department, a record number that dwarfs sums from past years, according to a Tribune analysis.

That amount — far above the \$82.6 million Mayor Brandon Johnson and aldermen budgeted for settlements, verdicts and legal fees involving the department — does not include many smaller payments that face less aldermanic scrutiny.

It also leaves out a whopping \$120 million a federal judge ordered the city to pay in March for two wrongful conviction cases — verdicts city leaders plan to challenge — and the oft-expensive cost of outside counsel retained by the city.

And the budget-swamping cost will grow this year as Chicago stares down dozens and dozens of pending wrongful conviction lawsuits and handles a backlog of cases that went unheard while

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